Heidel – Tablet XI (Assyrian version)

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Tablet XI 1

Footnotes (Heidel) 9

<!-- Extracted 2026-10-16 from Faded Page (Distributed Proofreaders Canada) e-text of A. Heidel, The Gilgamesh Epic and Old Testament Parallels (2nd ed. 1949), https://www.fadedpage.com/showbook.php?pid=20220136 . Line numbers are Heidel's. -->

Tablet XI

1. Gilgamesh said to him, to Utnapishtim the Distant:
2. “I look upon thee, Utnapishtim,
3. Thine appearance is not different; thou art like unto me.
4. Yea, thou art not different; thou art like unto me.
5. My heart had pictured thee as one perfect for the doing of battle;^[164]
6. [But] thou liest (idly) on (thy) side, (or) on thy back.
7. [Tell me], how didst thou enter into the company of the gods and obtain life (everlasting)?”
8. Utnapishtim said to him, to Gilgamesh:
9. “Gilgamesh, I will reveal unto thee a hidden thing,
10. Namely, a secret of the gods will I tell thee.

ll. Shurippak^[165]—a city which thou knowest,

12. [And which] is situated [on the bank of] the river Euphrates—
13. That city was (already) old, and the gods were in its midst.
14. (Now) their heart prompted the great gods [to] bring a deluge.
15. [There was(?)] Anu, their father;
16. Warlike Enlil, their counselor;
17. Ninurta, their representative;
18. Ennugi, their vizier;
19. Ninigiku, (that is,) Ea, also sat with them.
20. Their speech he repeated to a reed hut:^[166]
21. ‘Reed hut, reed hut! Wall, wall!
22. Reed hut, hearken! Wall, consider!
23. Man of Shurippak,^[167] son of Ubara-Tutu!
24. Tear down (thy) house, build a ship!
25. Abandon (thy) possessions, seek (to save) life!

26. Disregard (thy) goods, and save (thy) life!
27. [Cause to] go up into the ship the seed of all living creatures.
28. The ship which thou shalt build,
29. Its measurements shall be (accurately) measured;
30. Its width and its length shall be equal.
31. Cover it [li]ke the subterranean waters.'
32. When I understood this, I said to Ea, my lord:
33. '[Behold], my lord, what thou hast thus commanded,
34. [I] will honor (and) carry out.
35. [But what] shall I answer the city, the people, and the elders?'
36. Ea opened his mouth and said,
37. Speaking to me, his servant:
38. 'Thus shalt thou say to them:
39. [I have le]arned that Enlil hates me,
40. That I may no (longer) dwell in yo[ur ci]ty,
41. Nor turn my face to the land of Enlil.
42. [I will therefore g]o down to the apsû and dwell with Ea, my [lor]d.^[168]
43. [On] you he will (then) rain down plenty;
44. [.... of b]irds(?), ... of fishes.
45. [....] harvest-wealth.
46. [In the evening the leader] of the storm(?)^[169]
47. Will cause a wheat-rain to rain down upon you.'^[170]
48. As soon as [the first shimmer of mor]ning beamed forth,
49. The land was gathered [about me].

50-53. (Too fragmentary for translation)

54. The child [brou]ght pitch,
55. (While) the strong brought [whatever else] was needful.
56. On the fifth day [I] laid its framework.
57. One ikû^[171] was its floor space,^[172] one hundred and twenty cubits each was the height of its walls;
58. One hundred and twenty cubits measured each side of its deck.^[173]
59. I 'laid the shape' of the outside (and) fashioned it.^[174]
60. Six (lower) decks I built into it,
61. (Thus) dividing (it) into seven (stories),
62. Its ground plan I divided into nine (sections).^[175]
63. I drove water-stoppers into it.^[176]
64. I provided punting-poles and stored up a supply.^[177]
65. Six shar^[178] of pitch I poured into the furnace,
66. (And) three shar of asphalt [I poured] into it.

67. Three shar of oil the basket-carriers brought:^[179]
68. Besides a shar of oil which the saturation(?) (of the water-stoppers) consumed,^[180]
69. Two shar of oil [which] the boatman stowed away.
70. Bullocks I slaughtered for [the people];
71. Sheep I killed every day.
72. Must, red wine, oil, and white wine,^[181]
73. [I gave] the workmen [to drink] as if it were river water,
74. (So that) they made a feast as on New Year's Day.
75. I [....] ointment I put my hands.
76. [....].. the ship was completed.
77. Difficult was [the ....].
78. .... above and below.
79. [....].. its two-thirds.
80. [Whatever I had I] loaded aboard her.
81. Whatever I had of silver I loaded aboard her;
82. Whatever I [had] of gold I loaded aboard her;
83. Whatever I had of the seed of all living creatures [I loaded] aboard her.
84. After I had caused all my family and relations to go up into the ship,
85. I caused the game of the field, the beasts of the field, (and) all the craftsmen to go (into it).
86. Shamash set for me a definite time:
87. 'When the leader of the sto[rm(?)] causes a destructive rain to rain down in the evening,
88. Enter the ship and close thy door.'^[182]
89. That definite time arrived:
90. In the evening the leader of the sto[rm(?)] caused a destructive rain to rain down.
91. I viewed the appearance of the weather;
92. The weather was frightful to behold.
93. I entered the ship and closed my door.
94. For the navigation(?)^[183] of the ship to the boatman Puzur-Amurri
95. I intrusted the mighty structure with its goods.
96. As soon as the first shimmer of morning beamed forth,
97. A black cloud came up from out the horizon.
98. Adad^[184] thunders within it,
99. While Shullat and Ḫanish go before,
00. Coming as heralds over hill and plain;
01. Irragal^[185] pulls out the masts;
02. Ninurta^[186] comes along (and) causes the dikes to give way;
03. The Anunnaki^[187] raised (their) torches,
04. Lighting up the land with their brightness;^[188]
05. The raging of Adad reached unto heaven
06. (And) turned into darkness all that was light.

07. [....] the land he broke(?) like a po[t(?)].
08. (For) one day the tem[pest blew].
09. Fast it blew and [....].
10. Like a battle [it ca]me over the p[eople].
11. No man could see his fellow.
12. The people could not be recognized from heaven.
13. (Even) the gods were terror-stricken at the deluge.
14. They fled (and) ascended to the heaven of Anu;^[189]
15. The gods cowered like dogs (and) crouched in distress(?).
16. Ishtar cried out like a woman in travail;
17. The lovely-voiced Lady of the g[ods]^[190] lamented:
18. 'In truth, the olden time has turned to clay,
19. Because I commanded evil in the assembly of the gods!
20. How could I command (such) evil in the assembly of the gods!
21. (How) could I command war to destroy my people,
22. (For) it is I who bring forth^[191] (these) my people!
23. Like the spawn of fish they (now) fill the sea!'
24. The Anunnaki-gods wept with her;
25. The gods sat bowed (and) weeping.
26. Covered were their lips .....
27. Six days and [six] nights
28. The wind blew, the downpour, the tempest, (and) the flo[od] overwhelmed the land.
29. When the seventh day arrived, the tempest, the flood,
30. Which had fought like an army, subsided in (its) onslaught.
31. The sea grew quiet, the storm abated, the flood ceased.
32. I opened a window, and light fell upon my face.^[192]
33. I looked upon the sea,^[193] (all) was silence,
34. And all mankind had turned to clay;
35. The .... was as level as a (flat) roof.
36. I bowed, sat down, and wept,
37. My tears running down over my face.
38. I looked in (all) directions for the boundaries of the sea.
39. At (a distance of) twelve^[194] (double-hours) there emerged a stretch of land.
40. On Mount Niṣir^[195] the ship landed.
41. Mount Niṣir held the ship fast and did not let (it) move.
42. One day, a second day Mount Niṣir held the ship fast and did not let (it) move.
43. A third day, a fourth day Mount Niṣir held the ship fast and did not let (it) move.
44. A fifth day, a sixth day Mount Niṣir held the ship fast and did not let (it) move.^[196]
45. When the seventh day arrived,
46. I sent forth a dove and let (her) go.

47. The dove went away and came back to me;
48. There was no resting-place, and so she returned.
49. (Then) I sent forth a swallow and let (her) go.
50. The swallow went away and came back to me;
51. There was no resting-place, and so she returned.
52. (Then) I sent forth a raven and let (her) go.
53. The raven went away, and when she saw that the waters had abated,
54. She ate, she flew about,^[197] she cawed, (and) did not return.
55. (Then) I sent forth (everything) to the four winds and offered a sacrifice.
56. I poured out a libation on the peak of the mountain.
57. Seven and (yet) seven kettles I set up.
58. Under them I heaped up (sweet) cane, cedar, and myrtle.
59. The gods smelled the savor,
60. The gods smelled the sweet savor.
61. The gods gathered like flies over the sacrificer.
62. As soon as^[198] the great goddess^[199] arrived,
63. She lifted up the great jewels which Anu had made according to her wish:
64. 'O ye gods here present, as surely as I shall not forget the lapis lazuli on my neck,
65. I shall remember these days and shall not forget (them) ever!
66. Let the gods come near to the offering;
67. (But) Enlil shall not come near to the offering,
68. Because without reflection he brought on the deluge
69. And consigned my people to destruction!'
70. As soon as Enlil arrived
71. And saw the ship, Enlil was wroth;
72. He was filled with anger against the gods, the Igigi:^[200]
73. 'Has any of the mortals escaped? No man was to live through the destruction!'
74. Ninurta opened his mouth and said, speaking to warrior Enl[il]:
75. 'Who can do things without^[201] Ea?
76. For Ea alone understands every matter.'
77. Ea opened his mouth and said, speaking to warrior Enlil:
78. 'O warrior, thou wisest among the gods!
79. How, O how couldst thou without reflection bring on (this) deluge?
80. On the sinner lay his sin; on the transgressor lay his transgression!
81. Let loose, that he shall not be cut off; pull tight, that he may not ge[t (too) loose]^[202]
82. Instead of thy sending a deluge, would that a lion had come and diminished mankind!
83. (Or) instead of thy sending a deluge, would that a wolf had come and dim[inished] mankind!
84. (Or) instead of thy sending a deluge, would that a famine had occurred and [destroyed] the land!
85. (Or) instead of thy sending a deluge, would that Irra^[203] had come and smitten mankind!

36. (Moreover,) it was not I who revealed the secret of the great gods;
37. (But) to Atraḫasis^[204] I showed a dream, and so he learned the secret of the gods.
38. And now take counsel concerning him.
39. Then Enlil went up into the ship.
90. He took my hand and caused me to go aboard.
91. He caused my wife to go aboard (and) to kneel down at my side.
92. Standing between us, he touched our foreheads and blessed us:
93. 'Hitherto Utnapishtim has been but a man;
94. But now Utnapishtim and his wife shall be like unto us gods.
95. In the distance, at the mouth of the rivers, Utnapishtim shall dwell!'
96. So they took me and caused me to dwell in the distance, at the mouth of the rivers.
97. But now as for thee, who will assemble the gods unto thee,
98. That thou mayest find the life which thou seekest?
99. Come, do not sleep for six days and seven nights."
00. (But) as he sits (there) on his hams,
01. Sleep like a rainstorm blows upon him.
02. Utnapishtim says to her, to his wife:
03. "Look at the strong man who wants life (everlasting).
04. Sleep like a rainstorm blows upon him."
05. His wife says to him, to Utnapishtim the Distant:
06. "Touch him that the man may awake,
07. That he may return in peace on the road by which he came,
08. That through the gate through which he came he may return to his land."
09. Utnapishtim says to her, to his wife:
10. "Deceitful is mankind, he will try to deceive thee.^[205]
11. Pray, (therefore,) bake loaves of bread for him (and) place (them) at his head.
12. And the days that he has slept mark on the wall!"
13. She baked loaves of bread for him (and) placed (them) at his head;
14. And the days that he slept she noted on the wall.
15. His first loaf of bread was all dried out;
16. The second was ....; the third was (still) moist; the fourth was white, his ....;
17. The fifth was moldy; the sixth had (just) been baked;
18. The seventh—suddenly he^[206] touched him, and the man awoke.
19. Gilgamesh said to him, to Utnapishtim the Distant:
20. "Hardly did sleep spread over me,
21. When quickly thou didst touch me and rouse me."
22. Utnapishtim [said to him], to Gilgamesh:
23. "[.... Gilga]mesh, count thy loaves of bread!
24. [The days which thou didst sleep] may they be known to thee.
25. Thy [first] loaf of bread [is (already) all dried out];

26. [The second is ....]; the third is (still) moist; the fourth is white, thy ....;
27. [The fifth is mol]dy; the sixth has (just) been baked;
28. [The seventh—s]uddenly thou didst wake."
29. [Gilg]amesh said to him, to Utnapishtim the Distant:
30. "[Oh, what] shall I do, Utnapishtim, (or) where shall I go,
31. As the robber^[207] has (already) taken hold of my [member]s?
32. Death is dwelling [in] my bedchamber;
33. And wherever [I] set [my feet] there is death!"
34. Utnapishtim [said to him,] to Urshanabi, the boatman:
35. "Urshanabi, [may] the qua[y not re]joice in thee, may the place of crossing hate thee!
36. Him who walks about on its shore banish from its shore.
37. The man before whose face thou didst walk, whose body is covered with long hair,
38. The grace of whose members pelts have distorted,
39. Take him, Urshanabi, and bring him to the place of washing;
40. Let him wash his long hair (clean) as snow in water.
41. Let him throw off his pelts and let the sea carry (them) away, that his fair body may be seen.
42. Let the band around his head be replaced with a new one.
43. Let him be clad with a garment, as clothing for his nakedness.
44. Until he gets to his city,^[208]
45. Until he finishes his journey,
46. May (his) garment not show (any sign of) age, but may it (still) be quite new."
47. Urshanabi took him and brought him to the place of washing.
48. He washed his long hair (clean) as snow in [water].
49. He threw off his pelts, that the sea might carry (them) away,
50. (And that) his fair body appeared.
51. He rep[laced the band around] his head with a new one.
52. He clothed him with a garment, as clothing for his nakedness.
53. Until he [would come to his city],
54. Until he would finish his journey,
55. [(His) garment should not show (any sign of) age but] should (still) be quite new.
56. Gilgamesh and Urshanabi boarded the ship;
57. They launched the ship [on the billows] (and) glided along.
58. His wife said to him, to Utnapishtim the Distant:
59. "Gilgamesh has come hither, he has become weary, he has exerted himself,
60. What wilt thou give (him wherewith) he may return to his land?"
61. Then he, Gilgamesh, took a pole
62. And brought the ship near to the shore.^[209]
63. Utnapishtim [said] to him, [to] Gilgamesh:
64. "Gilgamesh, thou hast come hither, thou hast become weary, thou hast exerted thyself;
65. What shall I give thee (wherewith) thou mayest return to thy land?

36. Gilgamesh, I will reveal (unto thee) a hidden thing,
37. Namely, a [secret of the gods will I] tell thee:
38. There is a plant like a thorn ⌈....⌉.
39. Like a rose(?) its thorn(s) will pr[ick thy hands].
70. If thy hands will obtain that plant, [thou wilt find new life]."
71. When Gilgamesh heard that, he opened [....].
72. He tied heavy stones [to his feet];
73. They pulled him down into the deep, [and he saw the plant].
74. He took the plant, (though) it pr[icked his hands].
75. He cut the heavy stones [from his feet],
76. (And) the .... threw him to its shore.
77. Gilgamesh said to him, to Urshanabi, the boatman:
78. "Urshanabi, this plant is a wondrous(?) plant,
79. Whereby a man may obtain his former strength(?).^[210]
80. I will take it to Uruk, the enclosure, I will give (it) to eat ⌈....⌉ may cut off the plant(?).
81. Its name is 'The old man becomes young as the man (in his prime).'
82. I myself will eat (it) that I may return to my youth."^[211]
83. After twenty double-hours they broke off a morsel.
84. After thirty (additional) double-hours they stopped for the night.
85. Gilgamesh saw a pool with cold water;
86. He descended into it and bathed in the water.
87. A serpent perceived the fragrance of the plant;
88. It came up [from the water] and snatched the plant,
89. Sloughing (its) skin on its return.^[212]
90. Then Gilgamesh sat down (and) wept,
91. His tears flowing over his cheeks.
92. [....] of Urshanabi, the boatman:
93. "[For] whom, Urshanabi, have my hands become weary?
94. For whom is the blood of my heart being spent?
95. For myself I have not obtained any boon.
96. For the 'earth-lion'^[213] have I obtained the boon.
97. Now at (a distance of) twenty^[214] double-hours (such a) one(?) snatches it away (from me)!
98. When I opened the .....
99. I have found something that [has been s]et for a sign unto me; I will withdraw
00. And will leave the ship at the shore."^[215] After twenty [double-hours] they broke off a morsel.
01. After thirty (additional) double-hours they stopped for the night. When they arrived in Uruk, the enclosure,
02. Gilgamesh said to him, to Urshanabi, the boatman:

03. “Urshanabi, climb upon the wall of Uruk (and) walk about;
04. Inspect the foundation terrace and examine the brickwork, if its brickwork be not of burnt bricks,
05. And (if) the seven wise men did not lay its foundation!
06. One shar is city, one shar orchards, one shar prairie; (then there is) the uncultivated land(?) of the temple of Ishtar.
07. Three shar and the uncultivated land(?) comprise^[216] Uruk.”
08. O that today I had left^[217] the pukku in the house of the carpenter!

(Colophon:)

09. Tablet XI of “He who saw everything,” [of the series of] Gilgamesh.
10. Written down according to its original and collated.
11. Palace of Ashurbanipal, king of the world, king of Assyria.

Footnotes (Heidel)

[164] This translation was suggested to me by Dr. Jacobsen. With the above interpretation of the permansive of the pi‘el stem may be compared von Soden in Zeitschrift für Assyriologie, XLIII, p. 266, lines 22 ff.
[165] Usually called Shuruppak.
[166] Probably the dwelling of Utnapishtim. Some good photographs of reed houses have recently been published by John van Ess in The National Geographic Magazine, LXXXII (1942), 410-11.
[167] This expression, as shown by the following lines, refers to Utnapishtim.
[168] The apsû, the place where Ea had his dwelling, was the subterranean sweet-water ocean, from which, e.g., the water of the rivers and marshes was thought to spring forth. But here, in view of all the things Utnapishtim takes along, the reference probably is to the marshy area at the northern shores of the Persian Gulf.
[169] Cf. Thompson, op. cit., p. 86, note on line 46.
[170] Here the original obviously has a play on words, the purpose of which is to deceive the inhabitants of Shurippak to the last moment (see Carl Frank in Zeitschrift für Assyriologie, XXXVI [1925], 218). This line can also be translated: “He will cause a destructive rain (lit.: a rain of misfortune) to rain down upon you.” This evidently is the real meaning of the passage. But Ea knew that the people of Shurippak would interpret these words differently.
[171] About 3,600 square meters, or approximately an acre (see A. J. Sachs in the Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research, No. 96 [December, 1944], pp. 29-39).
[172] See Schott in Zeitschrift für Assyriologie, XLII, 137.
[173] Placing the Babylonian cubit at about half a meter (see the article by Sachs referred to above), the deck had a surface of approximately 3,600 square meters, or one ikû. Utnapishtim’s boat was an exact cube.

[174] The ship. Utnapishtim now attached the planking to the framework.
[175] Each of the seven stories was divided into nine sections, or compartments.
[176] This line probably means that he drove wedge-shaped pieces of wood between the seams to help make the boat watertight. Thus Paul Haupt in Beiträge zur Assyriologie, X, Heft 2 (1927), 6, and Armas Salonen, Die Wasserfahrzeuge in Babylonien (Helsinki, 1939), pp. 100-101.
[177] Or: what was needful (cf. line 55).
[178] Var.: three shar. One shar is 3,600. The measure is not given in these lines. Perhaps we have to supply sûtu; one sûtu was equal to a little over two gallons. Three shar would then correspond to about 24,000 gallons (cf. Schott, op. cit., p. 67, n. 11).
[179] If the translation "basket-carriers" is correct, we may perhaps assume that the baskets were coated with asphalt, or some such substance (so Haupt in Beiträge zur Assyriologie, X, Heft 2, 18). But I am rather inclined to believe that the oil was contained in vessels carried in some kind of slings. Thus in Egypt large pottery amphorae filled with wine were transported in netted pot-slings carried on a pole (for a beautiful and easily accessible illustration see the National Geographic Magazine, LXXX [1941], 495). The same mode of transportation is depicted on a plaque discovered by the Oriental Institute among the ruins of Opis, in Babylonia (a good picture of this plaque is found in J. H. Breasted, Ancient Times [Boston, etc., 1935], p. 155). Attention may be drawn also to the manner in which a demijohn is inclosed and carried. Salonen's view (op. cit., p. 15, n. 2), that sussullu denotes a kind of ladle, has been refuted by Meier in Orientalistische Literaturzeitung, Vol. XLIII, col. 306.
[180] See Salonen, op. cit., pp. 149-50.
[181] Cf. Poebel in Zeitschrift für Assyriologie, XXXIX, 146 ff.
[182] Var.: the ship.
[183] Thus Ebeling in Archiv für Orientforschung, VIII, 231, and Friedrich Delitzsch, Assyrisches Handwörterbuch (Leipzig, 1896), p. 519. The translation "for the calking of the ship," while obviously correct elsewhere (cf. Salonen, op. cit., p. 152), does not fit into the present context.
[184] The god of storm and rain.
[185] Another name for Nergal, the god of the underworld.
[186] God of war and lord of the wells and irrigation works (Knut Tallqvist, Akkadische Götterepitheta [Helsinki, 1938], pp. 424-26).
[187] The judges in the underworld.
[188] These two lines perhaps refer to sheet lightning on the horizon; forked lightning, which is accompanied by thunder peals, is attributed to Adad (Jensen, op. cit., p. 496, and Ebeling in Reallexikon der Assyriologie, I [Berlin and Leipzig, 1932], 24).
[189] The sky-god.
[190] Bêlit-i[lê].
[191] Lit.: give birth to.
[192] On the transposition of this line see Schott in Zeitschrift für Assyriologie, XLII, 139-40.
[193] Var.: at the weather.
[194] Var.: fourteen.

[195] This name could also be read Nimush.
[196] In place of the words “held the ship fast and did not let (it) move,” in lines 142-44, the original has the sign of reduplication or repetition, which means that the statement is to be completed on the basis of the preceding line. In this instance, the sign of reduplication could be rendered with “etc.”
[197] Cf. von Soden in Orientalistische Literaturzeitung, Vol. XXXVIII, col. 146.
[198] Cf. Jensen, op. cit., pp. 398 and 502.
[199] I.e., Ishtar.
[200] The gods of heaven.
[201] Cf. E. S. Rimalt in Wiener Zeitschrift für die Kunde des Morgenlandes, XXXIX (1932), 114-15.
[202] I.e., punish man, lest he get too wild; but do not be too severe, lest he perish (cf. Ebeling in Archiv für Orientforschung, VIII, 231).
[203] The god of pestilence.
[204] This name—in reality a descriptive epithet meaning “the exceedingly wise”—is another designation for Utnapishtim.
[205] I.e., he will deny that he slept (so Landsberger in Zeitschrift für Assyriologie, XLII, 141, n. 1.).
[206] Utnapishtim.
[207] I.e., death?
[208] Var.: to his land.
[209] Gilgamesh was no doubt called back by Utnapishtim.
[210] Cf. Schott in Zeitschrift für Assyriologie, XLII, 142.
[211] The purpose of this plant was to grant rejuvenated life; and it was to be eaten after a person had reached old age. For this reason Gilgamesh does not eat the plant at once but decides to wait until after his return to Uruk, until he has become an “old man” (cf. Christian in Wiener Zeitschrift für die Kunde des Morgenlandes, XL, 149).
[212] Cf. W. F. Albright in Revue d’Assyriologie, XVI (1919), 189-90. By eating this magic plant, the serpent gained the power to shed its old skin and thereby to renew its life (cf. J. Morgenstern in Zeitschrift für Assyriologie, XXIX [1914/15], 284 ff.).
[213] Apparently the serpent (cf. lines 287 ff. and Jensen in Orientalistische Literaturzeitung, Vol. XXXII, col. 650).
[214] We should expect “fifty” (cf. lines 283-84).
[215] In the loss of the plant Gilgamesh sees a sign that he should leave the ship behind and proceed by land. The boatman goes along, for, according to line 235, he apparently has been banished from the shores of the blessed for bringing Gilgamesh there.
[216] Reading tam-ḫu (thus Ebeling in Archiv für Orientforschung, VIII, 232).
[217] Adhering to the old reading, viz., e-⌈zib⌉.